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When you're trying to solve a problem on a new product type, you become completely focused on problems that seem a number of steps removed from the main product. That problem solving can appear a little abstract, and it is easy to lose sight of the product.

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Jony Ive and designing the default.

Teaching restraint to an industry that only understood “more”

By **Vyom Ramani** | editor@digit.in

In 1997, a computer was a beige box with a fan loud enough to argue with. Ten years later, that same category of object was something people carried in their pocket and touched four thousand times a day. Most of the industry treats that decade as an engineering story, faster chips, better batteries, thinner glass. It wasn't. It was a design story, and it had one author. Jony Ive didn't just make Apple's products look different. He made restraint the price of entry into consumer technology, and he made every competitor, including the ones that despised Apple's whole philosophy, perform a version of it whether they believed in it or not. That is the actual game he changed, and unlike most entries in this series, it isn't a bet still working itself out. It already happened. It's sitting in your pocket right now.

The rescue

Ive was Apple's design chief before Steve Jobs came back in 1997, quietly doing decent work inside a company that was eight weeks from bankruptcy and had no idea what it stood for. He was reportedly ready to leave. Jobs's return didn't invent Ive's talent, it

gave that talent a company willing to bet everything on it. The proof came fast. The 1998 iMac, translucent, Bondi Blue, curved like nothing else on a desk in a market that had standardised on grey plastic boxes, wasn't a cosmetic flourish. It was a decision that design could be Apple's entire turnaround strategy, not a coat of paint on top of one. It worked. The iMac sold out, Apple stopped bleeding cash, and design stopped being the department that showed up after engineering finished. From that point on, it was the department that decided what engineering was for.

The material argument

The next act was quieter and arguably more consequential. Through the 2000s, Ive pushed Apple away from injection-moulded plastic and toward machined aluminium, culminating in the unibody MacBook Pro, a single block of metal carved down to its final shape rather than assembled from parts. This wasn't just an aesthetic upgrade. It forced an entire supply chain to build CNC machining capacity at consumer scale, something that had never been economically justified before Apple